

My vort for אלול, which was inspired by a number of people including Rabbi Oelbaum, is as follows: We know that the month of אלול is distinctive in that every day we say וְיִשְׁעֵי אֲוִירֵי ה' לְדָוֹד ה'. In that קאפיטל there's the pasuk אֶחָת שְׁאֵלָתִי מֵאֵת ה' - there is only one thing that I'm asking for. Then we go home and we wash and we have a nice fresh roll and a little scrambled egg or whatever, and then we bentch. In bentching we say:

לָחֵן וּלְחֶסֶד וּלְרַחֲמִים וּלְגִיוֹחַ הַצֵּלָה וְהַצִּלָּה בְּרַכָּה וְיִשׁוּעָה, גְּחֵמָה, פְּרִנָּסָה וְכִלְכִּלָּה, וְרַחֲמִים, וְחַיִּים - I need, הקדוש ברוך הוא ומְכַל טוֹב לְעוֹלָם אֵל יְחַסְּרֵנוּ, And הקדוש ברוך הוא, in case I left anything out, וְשִׁלּוֹם, וְכָל טוֹב something, please throw in all the other good stuff that you can do.

So hang on. Ten seconds ago, you said, I'm only asking you one thing, אֶחָת שְׁאֵלָתִי. And now you're asking an entire list. It's an endless list. וְיִסְרְנוּ אֵל יְחַסְּרֵנוּ - it's an infinite list.

The תירוץ is there is one thing in bentching that we do not want. לא לִידֵי מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם - everything that I need should come directly from you, not from מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם. חס ושלום, we should never have to come on to מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם. Let me ask you a question. A kid comes home from school and he says, 'Ma, what's for supper?' So she gives him supper. Is that called מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? An older kid asks, 'Daddy, I'm getting בר מצוה, can I have a Borsalino?' 'Okay, you can have a Borsalino.' Is that מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? An even older kid comes along and says, 'Dad, can I borrow the car keys?' Is that מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? And even better, 'Can I have a car?' Is that מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם? No, that's not מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם. Why? Because that's called משפחה, that's called your family. When you're getting something from your father, mother, and family, that's not מִתְּנַת בְּשָׂר וָדָם.

What are we asking Hashem? אֶחָת שְׁאֵלָתִי מֵאֵת ה' ... שְׁבִתִּי בְּבֵית ה' כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּי - Hashem, I want to live in your house. I want to be part of your משפחה. I want to be close to you, as close as a father and a mother. When you ask שְׁבִתִּי בְּבֵית ה' כָּל יְמֵי חַיֵּי, the הקדוש ברוך הוא, that I want to live in your house, then you can ask for everything. That's why when we bentch, we can ask for everything. May we be זוכה that הקדוש ברוך הוא give us all the good things we ask for, לטובה, and to have a wonderful וחתומה טובה.

